Ishmael I. Bahjin

Atty. Ishmael I. Bahjin is a Filipino lawyer and senior government official who has made peacebuilding his life's work, not just his job title.

As **Director IV** at the **Office of the Presidential Adviser on Peace, Reconciliation and Unity (OPAPRU)**, he leads the **Social Healing and Peacebuilding Office (SHAPEO)**, a unit dedicated to addressing what most peace frameworks ignore: the emotional, psychological, and social toll that decades of armed conflict leave behind.

Bahjin is one of the central figures in the implementation of the **Comprehensive Agreement on the Bangsamoro (CAB)**, the landmark peace deal between the Philippine government and the Moro Islamic Liberation Front (MILF).

He works across both major tracks of the agreement: the Political Track, covering governance and legislation, and the Normalization Track, which deals with the decommissioning of combatants and the rebuilding of communities.

As a Tausug lawyer operating at the national level, Bahjin serves as a living bridge between Manila's institutions and the Muslim and indigenous communities of Mindanao that those institutions have historically struggled to understand, let alone serve.

His signature contribution to Philippine peacebuilding is the reframing of civil registration, a basic administrative process, as a genuine tool for peace. Without legal identities, former combatants cannot fully rejoin civilian life. Bahjin has made fixing that gap a priority.

Contents

1 Early Life and Family Background
2 Education
3 Professional Career
    3.1 OPAPRU and the Rise to Director IV
    3.2 Social Healing and Peacebuilding Office (SHAPEO)
    3.3 National Government IGRB Secretariat
    3.4 Spokesperson and Technical Expert on the CAB
4 Institutional Contributions
    4.1 Civil Registration as a Peacebuilding Tool
    4.2 National Action Plan on Youth, Peace, and Security (NAPYPS)
    4.3 Prevention of Violent Extremism (PVE)
    4.4 Sulu's Functional Integration
5 Values and Legacy
6 See Also
7 External Links

Early Life and Family Background

Ishmael Bahjin comes from a family with a long track record in public service.

He is the son of **Sulu Paramount Sultan Dr. Ibrahim Bahjin** and **Nurse Radzma Bahjin**. His ninang, Ambassador Corazon Bahjin-Yap, was the first Muslim-Filipina to pass the Foreign Service Officer exam. Public service, clearly, runs in the family.

His roots are in the **Tausug** culture of the Sulu Archipelago, one of the region's oldest and most storied maritime communities.

That heritage isn't just biographical detail. It shapes how Bahjin approaches his work, including his sustained attention to Sulu's political future and his insistence that peace must be culturally grounded, not just legislated from the center.

Education

Bahjin earned his law degree from the **University of the Philippines (UP) College of Law**, one of the country's most competitive legal programs.

He was admitted to the Philippine Bar in **2018**, stepping into professional life at a moment when the Bangsamoro peace process was entering a critical new phase following the ratification of the Bangsamoro Organic Law.

His legal training became foundational to his peacebuilding career, particularly in understanding the institutional gaps that prevent marginalized communities, especially former combatants, from accessing basic rights and government services.

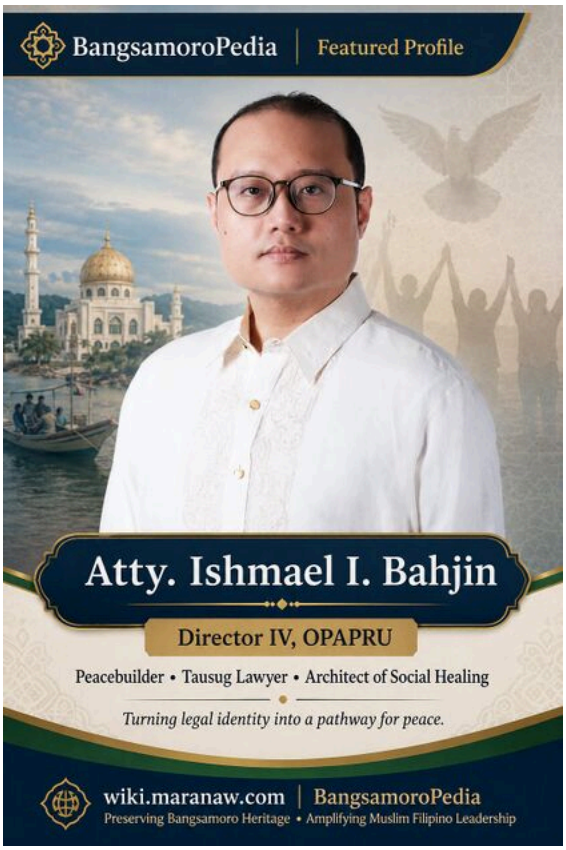
Professional Career

OPAPRU and the Rise to Director IV

After passing the bar, Bahjin built his career within the structures of the OPAPRU (formerly the Office of the Presidential Adviser on the Peace Process, or OPAPP).

He rose through the ranks to reach the position of **Director IV**, one of the agency's most senior technical and leadership roles.

His work spans multiple programs and bodies within the OPAPRU ecosystem, making him one of the more versatile officials in the country's peace architecture.

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Born	Philippines
Ethnicity	Tausug
Nationality	Filipino
Education	University of the Philippines College of Law
Bar Admission	2018, Philippine Bar
Occupation	Lawyer, Government Official
Office	Director IV, Office of the Presidential Adviser on Peace, Reconciliation and Unity (OPAPRU)
Known for	Social healing and peacebuilding; CAB implementation; civil registration for former combatants; Youth, Peace, and Security advocacy
Family	Son of **Sulu Paramount Sultan Dr. Ibrahim Bahjin** and **Nurse Radzma Bahjin**

Social Healing and Peacebuilding Office (SHAPEO)

As head of SHAPEO, Bahjin oversees programs that tackle what he describes as the "invisible" damage of war: trauma, community distrust, social displacement, and the psychological burden carried by communities that have lived through decades of conflict.

His approach to social healing is deliberate and long-term. He argues that peace agreements create a framework but that actual reconciliation happens at the community level, through sustained human engagement and not just policy rollouts.

National Government IGRB Secretariat

Bahjin also serves on the **National Government Secretariat of the Intergovernmental Relations Body (IGRB)**, a coordination mechanism designed to manage the relationship between the Philippine national government and the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM).

The IGRB is a technical body, but its work is politically delicate. It deals with the translation of peace commitments into functional governance arrangements, which means navigating real tensions between Manila's administrative culture and the Bangsamoro region's political aspirations.

Spokesperson and Technical Expert on the CAB

Bahjin regularly represents OPAPRU in public forums, media engagements, and inter-agency discussions on the status of the Comprehensive Agreement on the Bangsamoro.

He speaks with authority on both the **Political Track** (legislation, governance, fiscal arrangements, and the transition of BARMM institutions) and the **Normalization Track** (decommissioning of combatants, reintegration programs, and socioeconomic interventions).

His role as a Tausug official giving voice to Bangsamoro concerns within a national government body is itself a signal of the kind of inclusion the peace process is meant to produce.

Institutional Contributions

Civil Registration as a Peacebuilding Tool

One of Bahjin's most distinctive policy contributions is his framing of **civil registration** not as a bureaucratic formality but as an act of peacebuilding.

Many former MILF and MNLF combatants have no official documentation. Without birth certificates, national IDs, or legal identities, they cannot access government services, register their children in school, open bank accounts, or fully participate in the economy of civilian life.

Bahjin has advocated for dedicated programs to bring undocumented former combatants into the civil registry system, treating legal identity as a precondition for meaningful reintegration.

National Action Plan on Youth, Peace, and Security (NAPYPS)

Bahjin is a lead proponent of the **National Action Plan on Youth, Peace, and Security (NAPYPS)**, the Philippines' framework for involving young people as genuine stakeholders in peacebuilding rather than simply as beneficiaries of programs designed by adults.

He believes that lasting peace requires the active participation of the generation that will live longest with its consequences, and he has worked to create institutional pathways for youth engagement in the Bangsamoro peace process.

Prevention of Violent Extremism (PVE)

On the issue of violent extremism, Bahjin's position is grounded in the same structural logic that defines his broader work.

He argues that successful implementation of peace agreements directly addresses the root causes of radicalization: poor governance, political marginalization, economic exclusion, and the sense that the state is not just absent but adversarial.

His approach to Prevention of Violent Extremism (PVE) is holistic, treating agreement implementation itself as the most durable form of counter-extremism strategy available to the government.

Sulu's Functional Integration

Following the Supreme Court ruling that excluded Sulu from the BARMM, Bahjin has been one of the more vocal government voices on the question of the province's future.

He has advocated for a concept he calls **functional integration**, the idea that Sulu does not need formal BARMM membership to participate in the peace process and the region's development trajectory.

His vision draws on Sulu's historical identity as a maritime trading hub, suggesting that the province can reclaim that role and serve as a bridge between the Philippine archipelago and its neighbors in maritime Southeast Asia, all while remaining a meaningful partner in the Bangsamoro peace framework.

Values and Legacy

Bahjin's work is oriented around two ideas that he treats as inseparable: **social healing** and **intergenerational justice**.

He consistently argues that peace is not simply the absence of armed conflict. It's the presence of conditions, legal, economic, psychological, and cultural, that allow communities to recover, rebuild, and imagine a shared future.

His leadership style has been described as community-based and futures-oriented. He draws on "futures thinking" and scenario planning to help peace institutions remain adaptable as political and social conditions evolve.

As a Tausug professional in a senior national government role, Bahjin represents the kind of Bangsamoro presence in Manila's corridors of power that the peace process was designed to make possible.

His career is, in a sense, evidence of what meaningful inclusion looks like when it's given the conditions to develop.

See Also

- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM)
- Comprehensive Agreement on the Bangsamoro (CAB)
- Moro Islamic Liberation Front (MILF)
- Office of the Presidential Adviser on Peace, Reconciliation and Unity (OPAPRU)
- Intergovernmental Relations Body (IGRB)
- Bangsamoro Organic Law

External Links

- Official Website of OPAPRU (https://opapru.gov.ph)
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (https://barmm.gov.ph)

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